

THE WORLD CUP AND ECONOMICS

World Cup 2026: Predictions, Probabilities, and Paths to Victory

- We present a model for predicting the outcome of the 2026 World Cup in the US, Canada and Mexico from June 11 to July 19. It is similar to our model for prior World Cups but extended along several dimensions.
- Historical performance data for each team—most importantly the Elo rating system originally devised to rank chess players—is the main determinant of the number of goals scored. But even for a given Elo rating, we show that scoring talent and team momentum matter, as well as several mentality and geographical factors.
- We then simulate a set of probabilities that a particular team will reach a particular round, up to winning the World Cup. We also provide a modal forecast for how the tournament will unfold. After each day of play, we will re-run the model using updated performance data in order to generate new probabilities and a new modal forecast.
- The model says that Spain has a 26% probability of winning the trophy, followed by France at 19%, Argentina at 14%, Brazil at 8% and England at 5%. Spain is predicted to win because it has the highest Elo ranking, supported by scoring talent and good momentum into the competition. Argentina is penalised by the “winner’s slump”, i.e. the statistical underperformance of reigning champions in the following World Cup; France suffers from likely facing top-ranked Spain in the semifinals; and England underperforms its Elo rating given historical tournament disappointment, geographical headwinds (likely facing Mexico in high-altitude Mexico City), and a slightly unlucky draw.
- How much faith should we have in these predictions? Our projections are not far from bookmakers’ odds—except for a lower winning probability for England—and our model would have performed quite well at previous World Cups (for example, when measured with the goal difference). That said, the model’s statistical power remains limited—not a surprise given football’s inherent unpredictability.

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World Cup 2026: Predictions, Probabilities, and Paths to Victory

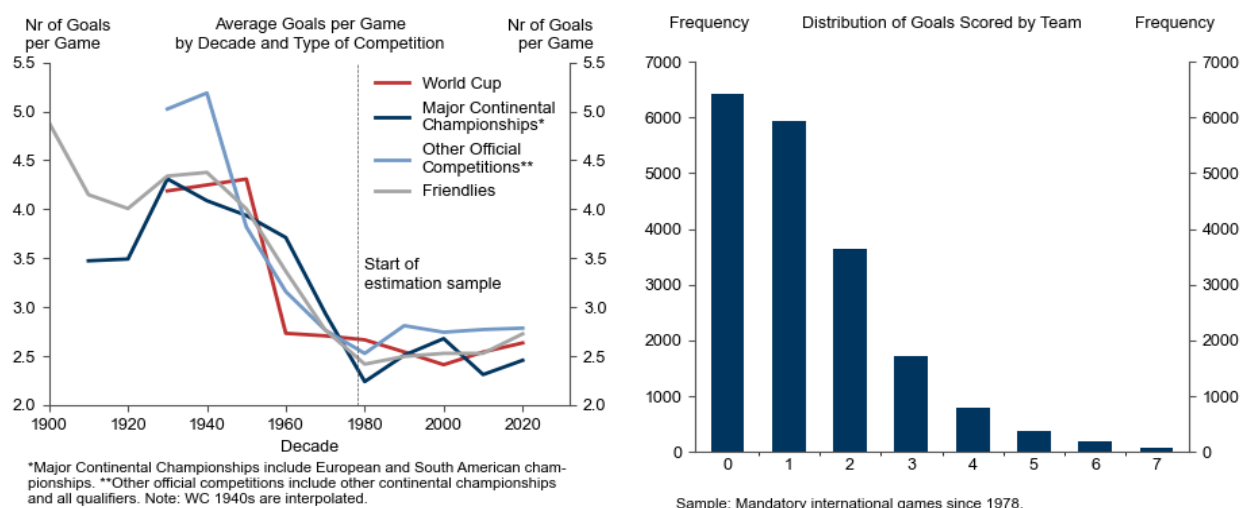
“Football is the most important of the least important things in life” - Arrigo Sacchi, Italian former football manager

With two weeks to go, we introduce our statistical model for predicting the outcome of the 2026 World Cup. We proceed as follows.

Our Statistical Model to Predict the Outcome of the World Cup

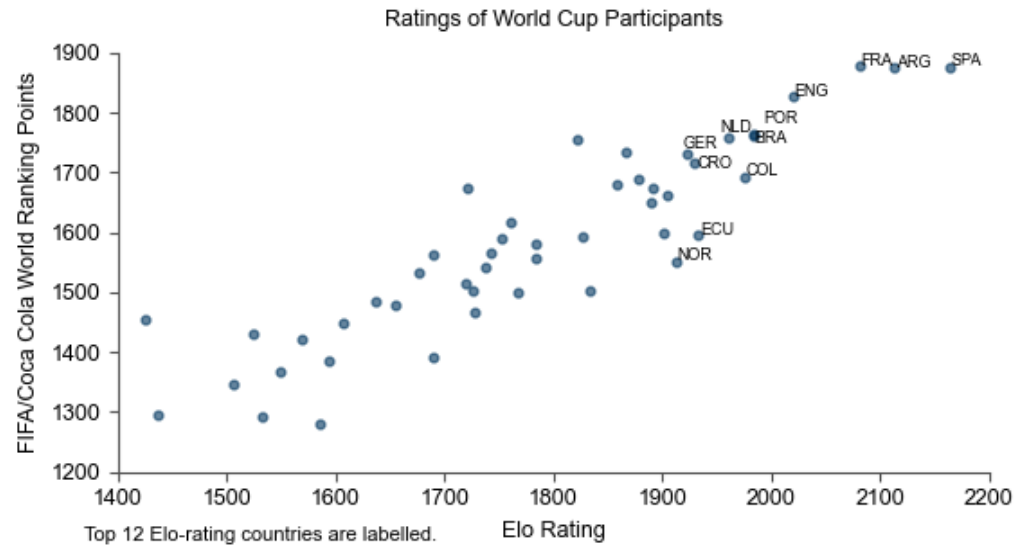
First, we estimate a regression model to predict the number of goals scored by a particular team (“team i”) against a particular opponent (“team j”) using the entire history of mandatory international matches since 1978 (a total of just under 20,000 matches). Following the literature on predicting football matches, we assume that the number of goals scored by team i is described by a so-called “Poisson” distribution ([Exhibit 1](#)).

Exhibit 1: The Number of Goals Score by a Football Team Broadly Follows a Poisson Distribution



Source: [eloratings.net](#), Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

The main determinant of the number of goals scored is the difference in team performance as reflected in [Elo ratings](#) prior to the match. The Elo system was originally devised to rank chess players. It is a composite measure of national football team success that evolves depending on a team’s results and the strength of its opponents. The Elo system ranks Spain first, followed by Argentina and France, and thus differs slightly from the FIFA men’s world [rankings](#) ([Exhibit 2](#)).

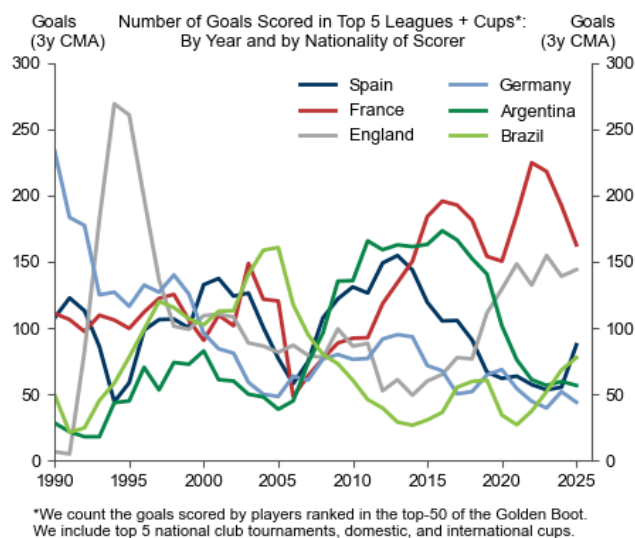
Exhibit 2: Elo vs FIFA/Coca-Cola Rankings

Source: eloratings.net, FIFA, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

We then expand the model with several other explanatory variables:

- **Scoring talent:** we gather data on top goal scorers in national leagues and international competitions for clubs and find that these matter for the number of goals scored by the team in a World Cup¹.
- **Momentum:** we measure team momentum by including the number of goals scored by team *i* in the last 10 competitive matches, and the number of goals conceded by team *j* in the last 5 competitive matches.
- **Mentality:** we find that reigning world champions typically underperform (while teams at their first World Cup usually outperform) and that it is more difficult to score against European teams (all else equal). Furthermore, major footballing nations generally get a World Cup boost, with the notable exception of England.
- **Geography:** we confirm a familiar “home effect” for games that are played at home. We also find that the number of goals scored is reduced: by the distance between the country’s capital and location of the game; when a low-altitude country plays in a high-altitude stadium (which is relevant for games played in Mexico in the upcoming World Cup); and by the absolute temperature difference between the average temperature of a country and the temperature of the venue in the month of the game.

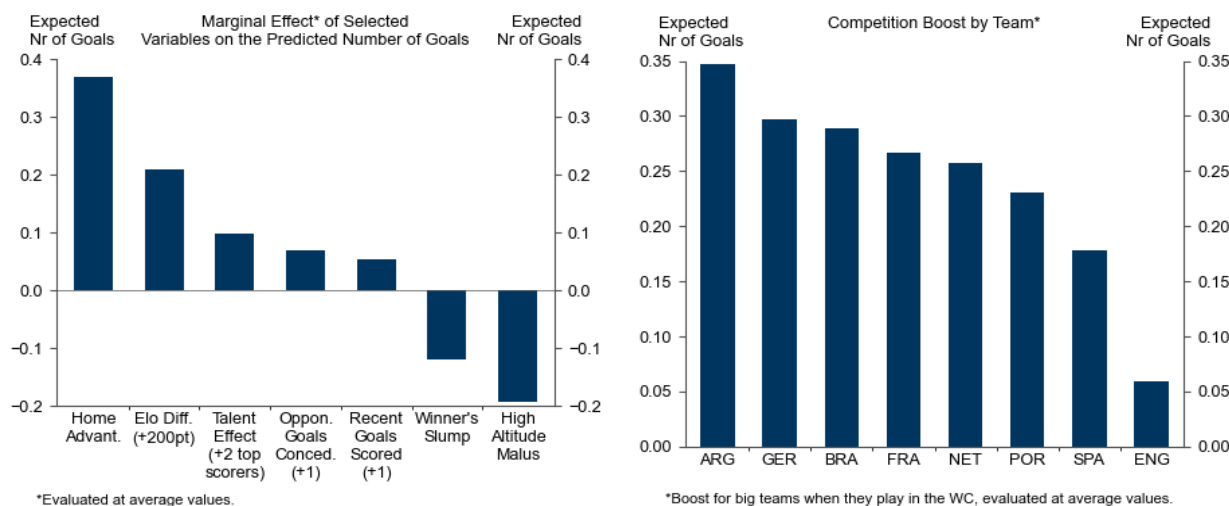
¹ We consider a counter-variable for the number of players in each national team ranked in the top 50 scorers in the top European club competitions, capped at 4 per team as it is rare to see more than 4 strikers on the pitch at the same time. Adding top scorers in the Copa Libertadores does not add to the fit.

Exhibit 3: Goal-Scoring Potential Matters; Some Signs of a “Winner’s Slump” Effect After Winning the World Cup

World Cup	Winner	Outcome in the Following World Cup
1978	Argentina	2nd Round
1982	Italy	Round of 16
1986	Argentina	2nd Place
1990	Germany	Quarter Finals
1994	Brazil	2nd Place
1998	France	Group Stage
2002	Brazil	Quarter Finals
2006	Italy	Group Stage
2010	Spain	Group Stage
2014	Germany	Group Stage
2018	France	2nd Place
2022	Argentina	TBC

Source: Transfermarkt, FIFA, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 4 summarises the marginal effect of some of the key variables in our model on the predicted number of goals scored in a World Cup game.

Exhibit 4: What Matters in Our Model

Source: Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Second, we apply this regression-based model to the upcoming World Cup. This entails simulating the group-stage games and the resulting bracket of the knock-out stage up to the final held on July 19 in New York. Our model updates Elo ratings and momentum variables recursively over the course of the tournament, according to model-based or, later, actual scores. We apply official FIFA rules for the tie-breakers in the group stage and account for all 495 possible pairings in the round of 32, which will depend on which third-placed teams qualify for the knock-out stage. We use the rounded prediction of the goals scored to determine the outcome of each match during the group stage and

the unrounded prediction to pick the winner in the knockout stage².

The model thus generates the single most likely prediction for each of the 104 games in the World Cup up to the final. We can also leverage the Poisson distribution underlying our model to run a Monte Carlo simulation with 50,000 draws, which yields a set of probabilities that a particular team wins the tournament or reaches a particular stage of the tournament. In each of the simulations, the outcome of a game is given by a random draw (as opposed to the most likely) from the team- and game-specific Poisson distribution of goals scored³.

A Summary of the Predictions

[Exhibit 5](#) and [Exhibit 6](#) show the most likely development of the tournament according to our model.

We expect major teams and all three hosts to advance from the expanded 48-team group stage to the round of 32. Groups D and G are expected to be the tightest ones, with our model unable to clearly differentiate (on a rounded basis) between the teams on the basis of the statistical factors considered. [Exhibit 12](#) in the Appendix shows the predicted standings at the group stage.

We expect the round of 32 to offer a few interesting games, including the US vs. Iran and a *clásico* Argentina vs. Uruguay. That said, the first “big matches” should be featured in the round of 16, with Germany projected to be eliminated by France. England vs. Brazil and Argentina vs. Portugal (which could be the last match-up between Lionel Messi and Cristiano Ronaldo) should be the most exciting quarter-finals, with the *Seleção* and the *Selección* advancing to the next stage. The Netherlands and the tournament surprise Türkiye are also expected to end their run in the quarter-finals.

The model projects semi-finals of France vs. Spain, and Brazil vs. Argentina, with *la Roja* and *la Albiceleste* (reigning continental champions respectively in Europe and South America) facing off in a *Finalissima*. We expect Spain to win its second World Cup on July 19, with Messi (who turns 39 during the tournament) passing on the torch to Lamine Yamal (who will celebrate his 19th birthday just a few days before the New York final). Our prediction aligns with the historical pattern that the World Cup almost always comes back to Europe after having been won by a South American team (with the only exception being the consecutive Brazilian wins in 1958 and 1962).

² We implicitly assume that our unrounded prediction is a good proxy for the outcome of a game in extra time or at penalties after a draw in the 90 minutes of regular time.

³ In the knock-out stage, we avoid draws by “burning” Monte Carlo draws that involve the same number of goals by the two teams. This mechanically boosts the chances of the team with the slightly higher mean predicted number of goals.

Exhibit 5: Most Likely Predicted Group Stage Results

FIFA World Cup 2026 - Group Stage: Prediction as of 29 May 2026

Played (final score)
 Predicted score

Group A <i>Mexico South Korea Czechia South Africa</i>				
MD	Date	Team 1	Score	Team 2
1	11-Jun	Mexico	2-0	South Africa
1	11-Jun	South Korea	1-1	Czechia
2	18-Jun	Czechia	1-1	South Africa
2	18-Jun	Mexico	2-1	South Korea
3	24-Jun	Czechia	1-2	Mexico
3	24-Jun	South Africa	1-1	South Korea

Group B <i>Canada Qatar Switzerland Bosnia and H.</i>				
MD	Date	Team 1	Score	Team 2
1	12-Jun	Canada	2-1	Bosnia and H.
1	13-Jun	Qatar	0-2	Switzerland
2	18-Jun	Switzerland	1-1	Bosnia and H.
2	18-Jun	Canada	2-1	Qatar
3	24-Jun	Switzerland	1-1	Canada
3	24-Jun	Bosnia and H.	1-1	Qatar

Group C <i>Brazil Haiti Scotland Morocco</i>				
MD	Date	Team 1	Score	Team 2
1	13-Jun	Brazil	2-1	Morocco
1	13-Jun	Haiti	1-1	Scotland
2	19-Jun	Scotland	1-1	Morocco
2	19-Jun	Brazil	2-1	Haiti
3	24-Jun	Scotland	1-2	Brazil
3	24-Jun	Morocco	1-1	Haiti

Group D <i>USA Australia Turkiye Paraguay</i>				
MD	Date	Team 1	Score	Team 2
1	12-Jun	USA	1-1	Paraguay
1	13-Jun	Australia	1-1	Turkiye
2	19-Jun	USA	1-1	Australia
2	19-Jun	Turkiye	1-1	Paraguay
3	25-Jun	Turkiye	1-1	USA
3	25-Jun	Paraguay	1-1	Australia

Group E <i>Germany Ivory Coast Ecuador Curacao</i>				
MD	Date	Team 1	Score	Team 2
1	14-Jun	Germany	2-1	Curacao
1	14-Jun	Ivory Coast	1-1	Ecuador
2	20-Jun	Germany	2-1	Ivory Coast
2	20-Jun	Ecuador	2-1	Curacao
3	25-Jun	Curacao	1-1	Ivory Coast
3	25-Jun	Ecuador	1-2	Germany

Group F <i>Netherlands Sweden Tunisia Japan</i>				
MD	Date	Team 1	Score	Team 2
1	14-Jun	Netherlands	1-1	Japan
1	14-Jun	Sweden	1-1	Tunisia
2	20-Jun	Netherlands	2-1	Sweden
2	20-Jun	Tunisia	1-1	Japan
3	25-Jun	Japan	1-1	Sweden
3	25-Jun	Tunisia	1-2	Netherlands

Group G <i>Belgium Iran New Zealand Egypt</i>				
MD	Date	Team 1	Score	Team 2
1	15-Jun	Belgium	1-1	Egypt
1	15-Jun	Iran	1-1	New Zealand
2	21-Jun	Belgium	1-1	Iran
2	21-Jun	New Zealand	1-1	Egypt
3	26-Jun	Egypt	1-1	Iran
3	26-Jun	New Zealand	1-1	Belgium

Group H <i>Spain Saudi Arabia Uruguay Cape Verde</i>				
MD	Date	Team 1	Score	Team 2
1	15-Jun	Spain	3-0	Cape Verde
1	15-Jun	Saudi Arabia	1-1	Uruguay
2	21-Jun	Spain	3-0	Saudi Arabia
2	21-Jun	Uruguay	1-1	Cape Verde
3	26-Jun	Uruguay	0-2	Spain
3	26-Jun	Cape Verde	1-1	Saudi Arabia

Group I <i>France Iraq Norway Senegal</i>				
MD	Date	Team 1	Score	Team 2
1	16-Jun	France	2-1	Senegal
1	16-Jun	Iraq	1-2	Norway
2	22-Jun	France	3-0	Iraq
2	22-Jun	Norway	1-1	Senegal
3	26-Jun	Norway	1-2	France
3	26-Jun	Senegal	2-1	Iraq

Group J <i>Argentina Austria Jordan Algeria</i>				
MD	Date	Team 1	Score	Team 2
1	16-Jun	Argentina	2-1	Algeria
1	16-Jun	Austria	1-1	Jordan
2	22-Jun	Argentina	2-1	Austria
2	22-Jun	Jordan	1-1	Algeria
3	27-Jun	Algeria	1-1	Austria
3	27-Jun	Jordan	1-2	Argentina

Group K <i>Portugal Uzbekistan Colombia DR Congo</i>				
MD	Date	Team 1	Score	Team 2
1	17-Jun	Portugal	2-1	DR Congo
1	17-Jun	Uzbekistan	1-1	Colombia
2	23-Jun	Portugal	2-1	Uzbekistan
2	23-Jun	Colombia	2-1	DR Congo
3	27-Jun	Colombia	1-1	Portugal
3	27-Jun	DR Congo	1-1	Uzbekistan

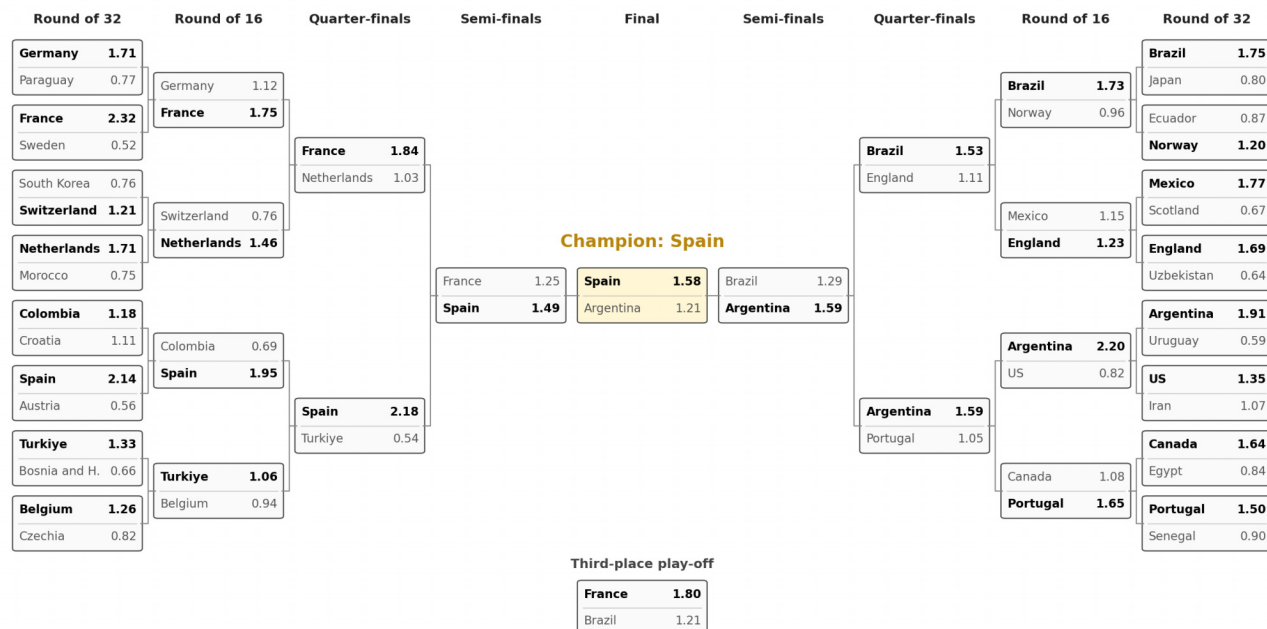
Group L <i>England Ghana Panama Croatia</i>				
MD	Date	Team 1	Score	Team 2
1	17-Jun	England	1-1	Croatia
1	17-Jun	Ghana	1-1	Panama
2	23-Jun	England	2-1	Ghana
2	23-Jun	Panama	1-2	Croatia
3	27-Jun	Panama	1-2	England
3	27-Jun	Croatia	2-1	Ghana

Source: Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 6: The Road to the Final

FIFA World Cup 2026 - Knock-Out Stage: GS Prediction as of 29 May 2026

Predicted unrounded goals shown next to each team. Winner in bold.



Source: Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

The probabilities resulting from our Monte Carlo simulation are shown in [Exhibit 7](#). The model says that Spain has a 26% probability of winning the trophy, followed by France at 19%, Argentina at 14%, Brazil at 8% and England and the Netherlands around 5%.

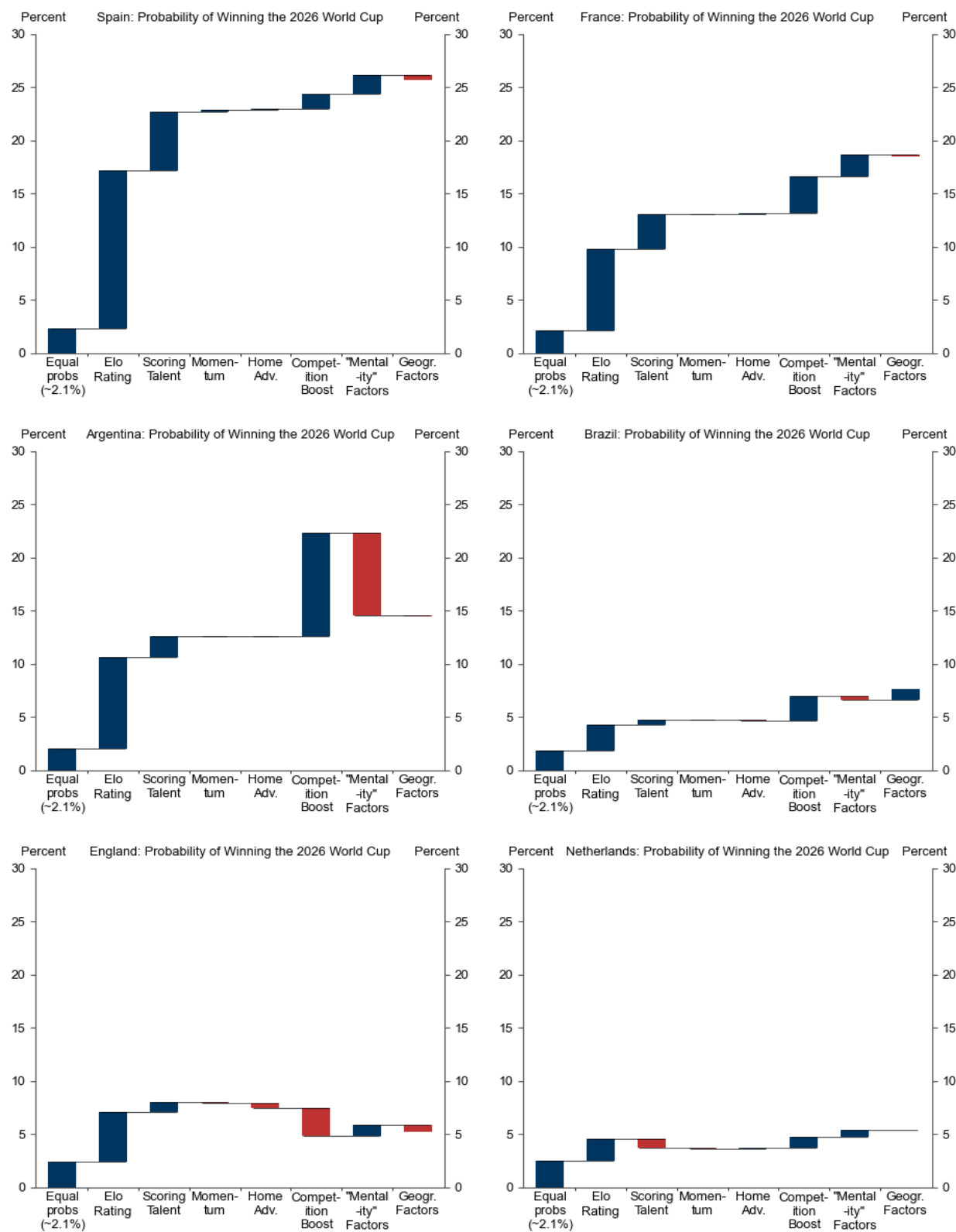
Exhibit 7: Probabilities of Advancement in the 2026 World Cup

Model-Implied Probabilities of Advancing in the 2026 World Cup (as of 29 May 2026)													
Team	R32	R16	QF	SF	Final	Winner	Team	R32	R16	QF	SF	Final	Winner
Spain	99.1	80.6	65.1	55.3	37.5	25.7	Uzbekistan	54.5	18.9	6.2	2.0	0.6	0.2
France	96.2	82.4	61.9	47.0	28.9	18.9	Australia	59.4	28.1	9.9	2.6	0.8	0.2
Argentina	96.5	70.0	57.3	42.4	27.1	14.3	Czechia	68.7	32.5	10.0	2.3	0.7	0.2
Brazil	96.1	66.9	45.3	28.4	15.9	7.6	Scotland	64.3	18.6	7.2	2.0	0.6	0.1
Netherlands	94.3	61.6	45.9	22.7	11.0	5.2	Algeria	50.3	13.7	5.0	1.5	0.4	0.1
England	94.1	65.9	37.7	22.2	11.5	5.0	Iran	71.6	30.3	9.7	2.2	0.5	0.1
Portugal	90.2	61.4	37.9	21.0	11.0	4.8	Panama	58.0	17.9	5.3	1.6	0.4	0.1
Germany	95.0	67.0	32.1	19.9	9.5	4.5	Jordan	47.9	13.7	5.2	1.7	0.4	0.1
Colombia	87.4	51.5	26.7	13.2	5.9	2.2	South Korea	71.2	34.5	10.6	2.0	0.5	0.1
Croatia	87.4	49.1	22.5	11.3	4.9	1.7	Egypt	60.7	22.0	6.2	1.4	0.3	0.1
Norway	78.0	47.4	23.7	11.8	4.8	1.6	Sweden	54.2	13.0	5.0	1.4	0.4	0.1
Mexico	95.6	68.0	33.3	10.2	3.4	0.8	Ivory Coast	54.8	14.9	3.3	0.9	0.2	0.0
Senegal	70.4	37.5	16.8	7.3	2.6	0.8	DR Congo	34.9	8.7	2.1	0.6	0.1	0.0
Ecuador	84.6	42.1	15.3	6.8	2.3	0.8	Bosnia and Herz.	63.2	22.7	6.2	1.1	0.2	0.0
Belgium	86.3	51.6	23.9	6.8	2.3	0.7	Cape Verde	42.2	7.9	2.3	0.6	0.1	0.0
Switzerland	88.9	54.2	21.8	6.7	2.2	0.7	New Zealand	52.9	17.2	4.3	0.8	0.2	0.0
Türkiye	77.3	45.9	21.8	6.8	2.2	0.6	Tunisia	39.0	7.4	2.3	0.6	0.1	0.0
United States	69.5	38.9	17.1	5.4	1.7	0.5	Haiti	29.4	5.4	1.3	0.3	0.1	0.0
Japan	78.9	30.7	16.0	5.6	1.8	0.5	Iraq	22.0	5.7	1.4	0.3	0.1	0.0
Austria	69.4	23.9	11.2	4.7	1.6	0.4	Saudi Arabia	35.0	5.5	1.4	0.2	0.0	0.0
Uruguay	79.9	26.5	12.9	5.3	1.7	0.4	South Africa	31.8	8.7	1.6	0.2	0.0	0.0
Paraguay	67.0	35.4	13.9	4.1	1.2	0.3	Curacao	31.5	6.1	1.0	0.2	0.0	0.0
Morocco	76.1	26.9	11.9	3.7	1.1	0.3	Ghana	26.4	5.1	1.0	0.2	0.0	0.0
Canada	90.7	50.4	18.4	4.7	1.2	0.3	Qatar	27.5	5.5	0.9	0.1	0.0	0.0

Source: Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

[Exhibit 8](#) provides more insight into the results by breaking down the probabilities of winning for the top four teams in a “waterfall chart” format. Our key predictions are:

- Spain is supported by its top Elo rating (52 points more than Argentina and 84 points above France) and scoring talent.
- Argentina is supported by a strong competition boost and the second-highest Elo rating but affected negatively by the winner's slump, as reigning World Cup winners consistently underperform (the only recent exception is France 2018-22).
- France boasts elite scoring talent but suffers from likely facing Spain earlier than Argentina (already in the semi-finals).
- England faces the twin obstacles of historical underperformance at World Cups and the likelihood of facing Mexico in hot and high-altitude Mexico City, which results in a net-drag from geographical factors on the Three Lions' chances.
- Germany is the only top team with no contribution from offensive talent. This is because relative to others they have fewer big scorers.

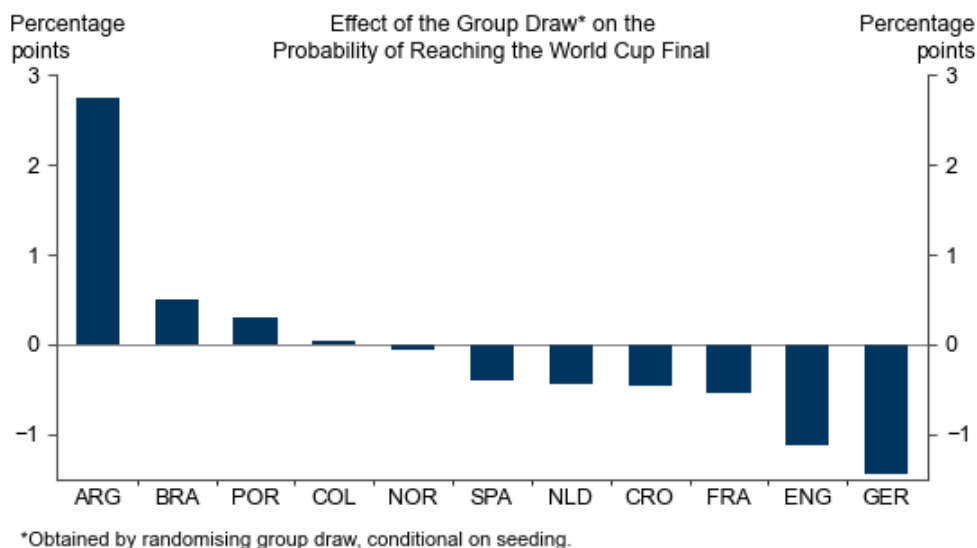
Exhibit 8: Breaking Down the Winning Probability

Source: elorating.net, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

An important (and highly debated) factor in all major football tournaments is the draw. We leverage our model to see how the draw affects the probabilities of reaching the final

by re-running simulations in a scenario where groups are randomised (conditional on seeding, [Exhibit 9](#)). Our analysis suggests that Germany was the least lucky team in the draw as they are predicted to face France in the round of 16. Argentina was, according to our model, the luckiest as they are likely to face top-ranked Spain only in the final.

Exhibit 9: The Luck of the Draw

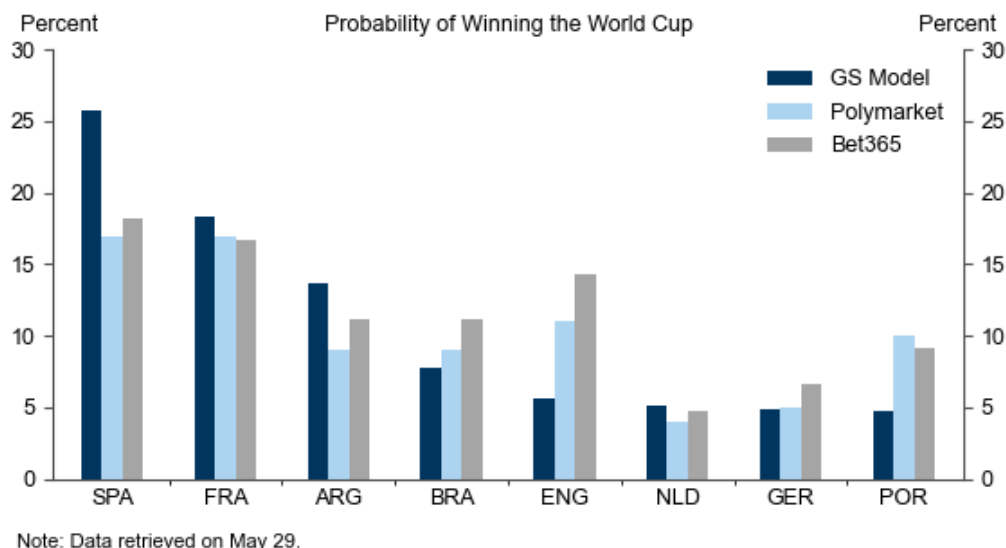


We randomise group composition, conditional on having in all groups one team from each pot.

Source: Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

We can also compare our probabilities to the market ([Exhibit 10](#)). We are overweight Spain and Argentina and underweight England and Portugal.

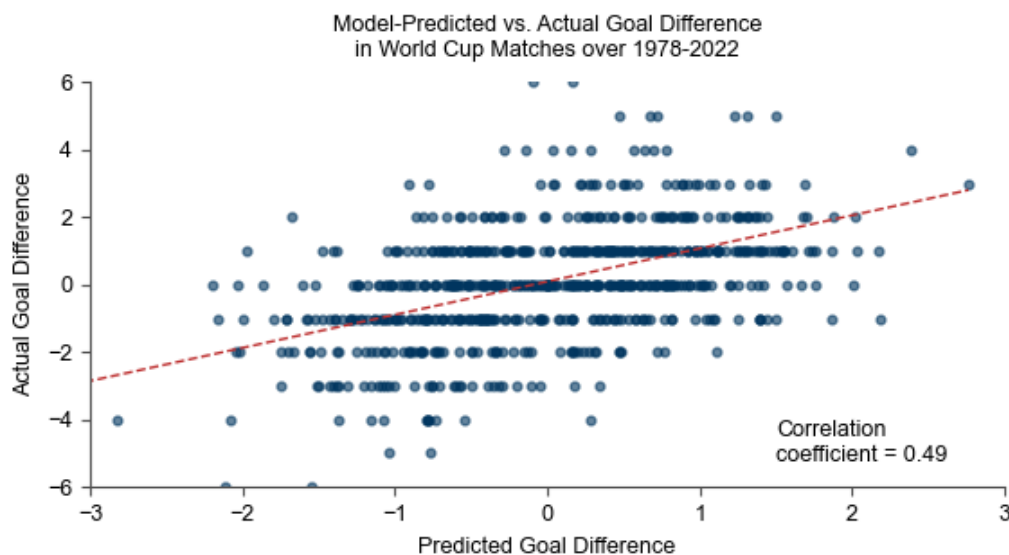
While our expanded model accounts for a larger set of factors than our previous attempts, it remains largely blind to the non-attacking talent (*e.g. the depth of the French and Portuguese midfield and wings or the role of good keepers in a penalty shootout*), health (*will Lamine Yamal's recent injury weigh on his performance in the World Cup?*), individual momentum (*will the many French players at PSG benefit from their deep run in the Champions League? Will Messi and Ronaldo be competitive after a few years away from top European football?*), or managerial experience (*an Ancelotti effect for Brazil?*). Furthermore, our model treats the number of goals scored by each team involved in a game as independent distributions, which leads to several predicted draws.

Exhibit 10: Comparing Our Model Probabilities to the Market

Source: Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research, Polymarket, Bet365

Another useful check is to evaluate what our model would have suggested ahead of the 2022 World Cup. The predicted winning probabilities ahead of the start of the tournament would have been Brazil (24% chances of winning), followed by Argentina (21%) and France (19%). This broadly mirrored the bookmakers' implied odds of Brazil (18%), Argentina (13%), and France (12%).

We can also look at the correlation between actual and predicted goal difference historically, which is ultimately what our model is trained to predict. The correlation of our model is 49% across all World Cup games since 1978, 43% in 2018, and 45% in 2022. While the correlation remains modest—given football's inherent unpredictability—the model improved over previous frameworks ([Exhibit 11](#)).

Exhibit 11: Assessing Our Model's Past Performance

Source: Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Throughout the tournament, in a short comment after each match day, we will be commenting on how the incoming results compare to our predictions, preview the games of the following day, and update the most-likely and probabilistic predictions of our model.

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Appendix: The Group Stage Standings

We leverage official FIFA rules to tie breaks and rank the 3rd-placed teams, with the top 8 advancing to the round of 32. In the event our model is unable to distinguish between teams using FIFA rules (e.g. in a group with predicted draws in all games on a rounded basis, given we don't model red and yellow cards), we rely on the predicted unrounded goal difference.

Exhibit 12: The Predicted Group Standings

FIFA World Cup 2026 - Final Group Standings (Prediction as of 29 May 2026)

Qualified (1st / 2nd)

Qualified as best-3rd

Eliminated

Group A						
Pos	Team	GF	GA	GD	Pts	Q
1	Mexico	6	2	+4	9	Top-2
2	South Korea	3	4	-1	2	Top-2
3	Czechia	3	4	-1	2	Best-3rd
4	South Africa	2	4	-2	2	Out

Group B						
Pos	Team	GF	GA	GD	Pts	Q
1	Canada	5	3	+2	7	Top-2
2	Switzerland	4	2	+2	5	Top-2
3	Bosnia and H.	3	4	-1	2	Best-3rd
4	Qatar	2	5	-3	1	Out

Group C						
Pos	Team	GF	GA	GD	Pts	Q
1	Brazil	6	3	+3	9	Top-2
2	Morocco	3	4	-1	2	Top-2
3	Scotland	3	4	-1	2	Best-3rd
4	Haiti	3	4	-1	2	Out

Group D						
Pos	Team	GF	GA	GD	Pts	Q
1	Turkiye	3	3	+0	3	Top-2
2	USA	3	3	+0	3	Top-2
3	Paraguay	3	3	+0	3	Best-3rd
4	Australia	3	3	+0	3	Out

Group E						
Pos	Team	GF	GA	GD	Pts	Q
1	Germany	6	3	+3	9	Top-2
2	Ecuador	4	4	+0	4	Top-2
3	Ivory Coast	3	4	-1	2	Out
4	Curacao	3	5	-2	1	Out

Group F						
Pos	Team	GF	GA	GD	Pts	Q
1	Netherlands	5	3	+2	7	Top-2
2	Japan	3	3	+0	3	Top-2
3	Sweden	3	4	-1	2	Best-3rd
4	Tunisia	3	4	-1	2	Out

Group G						
Pos	Team	GF	GA	GD	Pts	Q
1	Belgium	3	3	+0	3	Top-2
2	Iran	3	3	+0	3	Top-2
3	Egypt	3	3	+0	3	Best-3rd
4	New Zealand	3	3	+0	3	Out

Group H						
Pos	Team	GF	GA	GD	Pts	Q
1	Spain	8	0	+8	9	Top-2
2	Uruguay	2	4	-2	2	Top-2
3	Cape Verde	2	5	-3	2	Out
4	Saudi Arabia	2	5	-3	2	Out

Group I						
Pos	Team	GF	GA	GD	Pts	Q
1	France	7	2	+5	9	Top-2
2	Norway	4	4	+0	4	Top-2
3	Senegal	4	4	+0	4	Best-3rd
4	Iraq	2	7	-5	0	Out

Group J						
Pos	Team	GF	GA	GD	Pts	Q
1	Argentina	6	3	+3	9	Top-2
2	Austria	3	4	-1	2	Top-2
3	Algeria	3	4	-1	2	Out
4	Jordan	3	4	-1	2	Out

Group K						
Pos	Team	GF	GA	GD	Pts	Q
1	Portugal	5	3	+2	7	Top-2
2	Colombia	4	3	+1	5	Top-2
3	Uzbekistan	3	4	-1	2	Best-3rd
4	DR Congo	3	5	-2	1	Out

Group L						
Pos	Team	GF	GA	GD	Pts	Q
1	England	5	3	+2	7	Top-2
2	Croatia	5	3	+2	7	Top-2
3	Panama	3	5	-2	1	Out
4	Ghana	3	5	-2	1	Out

Source: Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

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Reg AC

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